| RAHUL GANDHI | 53 | Congress MP |

Forever Yatri

RAHUL CONTINUES HIS SEARCH FOR AN ALTERNATE PARADIGM WITHIN HIMSELF. AFTER A DISQUALIFICATION BURNISHED HIS STREET CRED, HE WILL NOW GO EAST TO WEST ON INDIA'S MAP

By Kaushik Deka

THE JOURNEY IS THE DESTINATION, THEY SAY, and the pilgrim's progress Rahul Gandhi marks often seems cut of that cloth. A second edition of the Bharat Jodo Yatra (BJY) is coming up—just around the bend where we turn into 2024. This time, it's called the Bharat Nyay Yatra (BNY), the tweak in the name denoting a new thematic focus: "securing economic, social and political justice" for the people of India. Starting on January 14, just a week before the other show heats up in Ayodhya, it will be a bus yatra for the most part, interspersed with short stretches where he will hit the ground walking, as in BJY. The caravan trail and the footfalls will follow the sun, kicking up dust along a trail from Manipur in the east, across 85 districts in 14 states, all the way to Mumbai on the western front, where all may not be quiet when he arrives on March 20. That will square the circle, the one he had left open-ended in January 2023, when the original epic wound to its ecstatic close in Srinagar. He had stood there in driven snow, looking a bit messianic, clad in a grey *pheran*, his white-flecked beard marking the length of his five-month padayatra.

It might have been tempting to look at Rahul as a case-study in isolation as he completes his cross-stitch on India's map. But with the storm-clouds of a poll campaign building to peak intensity around that time, such theoretical abstraction won't be possible. The rich lode of paradoxes he offers will have to be seen in a compellingly live, dramatic, unfolding context. Can he afford to have BNY continue that stance of ascetic detachment from the grime of electoral politics? Is he practising some form of immersive politics or is he still open to the charge of being a permanent dilettante? Has he had it too easy due to his lineage, or has it also been an encumbrance—a monkey on the back? Is he an asset or a liability? These questions have dogged Rahul despite the increasing ease with which he was taking centrestage as the Opposition's chief protagonist in the Lok Sabha, his

PILGRIM'S PROGRESS

- Rahul will embark on a 6,200-km Bharat Nyay Yatra on January 14—just a week ahead of BJP's big moment in Ayodhya
- The yatra, mostly by bus but with a few pedestrian patches, has also been given a significant starting point: the strife-torn landscape of Manipur
- Covering 85 districts in 14 states, it will wend its way to Mumbai by March 20, climaxing just weeks before the general election
- After BJY, a Congress win in Karnataka and an LS disqualification kept up the focus on Rahul